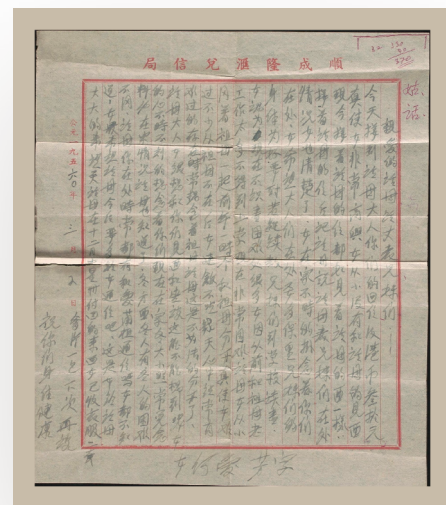


NATIONAL MUSEUM OF SINGAPORE • RESEARCH FELLOWSHIP 2024

If letters home could *sing*.

A biometric installation giving voice
to Hainanese women

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HE AIFANG TO HE QINGE, 2 MARCH
1960

NMS ACCESSION NO. 2000-06963-004

*Ordinary lives crossed
borders in ink. The
installation asks what
happens when a visitor meets
those voices through the
rhythm already inside them.*

ABSTRACT

7 MIN OVERVIEW • 18 MIN PAPER

This research explores the intersection of cultural heritage, interactive design, and embodied experience to transform static historical Chinese diaspora correspondence into dynamic, living encounters. Focusing on *qiao pi* (侨批), or “letters home,” it centres Hainanese women’s voices and brings their “history from below” to life through heart rate-synchronised sound experiences.

• qiao pi • embodied heritage • biometric interaction • Chinese diaspora • counter-narratives

1. Introduction: The Politics of Transnational Chinese Correspondence

This research explores the intersection of cultural heritage, interactive design, and embodied experience to transform static historical Chinese diaspora correspondence into dynamic, living encounters. Focusing on *qiao pi* (侨批) or “letters home” held in the National Museum of Singapore’s collection, we address a fundamental challenge in cultural heritage presentation: how to make historical correspondence emotionally resonant with contemporary audiences while challenging dominant interpretive frameworks.

Chinese *qiao pi*—remittance letters sent by overseas Chinese to their families from the 19th to mid-20th centuries—were recognised by UNESCO as Memory of the World in 2013, acknowledging their significance as crucial lifelines connecting diaspora communities with their families in China (UNESCO, 2013). Despite this recognition, a comprehensive review of existing research reveals significant gaps, particularly regarding marginalised voices and innovative presentation methods.

1.1 DOMINANT NARRATIVES: NATIONALISM AND HISTORICAL CONTEXTUALISATION

A significant body of scholarship positions *qiao pi* within nationalist frameworks that emphasise patriotic loyalty to the Chinese motherland. This instrumentalisation is evident in both academic literature and museum presentations, creating what Wang (2019) describes as patriotic educational tools through the display of *qiao pi* archives.¹

This state-sanctioned narrative prioritises content demonstrating how “overseas Chinese elevated their love for family, clan, and hometown to love for their motherland” (Bai, 2018, p. 131).² Scholars like Ye (2022) explicitly position *qiao pi* as materials for

promoting “traditional Chinese virtues such as patriotism” and conducting “patriotic education.”³ Similarly, Lin and Huang (2020) document how *qiao pi* are used in education to cultivate “patriotic sentiments” through historical stories related to “loving the party and country.”⁴

Historical contextualisation studies frequently reinforce these nationalist frameworks. Zheng (2019) frames *qiao pi* as evidence of how overseas Chinese “threw themselves into revolutionary activities and anti-Japanese resistance movements.”⁵ Chen and Cen (2021) analyse patriotic sentiments in family correspondence during the war against Japan, showing how resistance to Japanese aggression strengthened cultural identification with China. This historical contextualisation extends to earlier periods as well, with Bai (2018) documenting overseas Chinese involvement in the 1911 Revolution.

While patriotic sentiments may indeed appear in some correspondences, particularly during periods of national crisis, this dominant interpretive framework risks creating a monolithic narrative that filters overseas Chinese experiences primarily through the lens of state interests. The focus on nationalist themes overshadows the transnational nature of these communications, where identities were negotiated across borders rather than simply affirming singular national allegiances.

1.2 INSTITUTIONAL AND ECONOMIC NETWORKS

Scholarship examining the institutional infrastructure of *qiao pi* focuses primarily on remittance houses (*qiao pi ju*) and their transnational banking networks. Dai (2003) pioneered research on these networked enterprises, analysing how they operated within embedded social structures, while his subsequent work examined the transition between traditional and modern business systems as *qiao pi ju* developed relationships with formal banking institutions (Dai, 2004). Building on this foundation, Jiao (2010) explored the construction and operation of transnational commercial networks, particularly in Fujian.

Western scholarship has similarly recognised these sophisticated financial mechanisms. Harris (2013) analysed “the organisational structure and business practices of Qiaopiju” (p. 130), demonstrating how these firms adapted to emerging regulatory regimes across borders. Benton and Liu (2018) dedicate entire chapters in their book *Dear China* to examining “The Structure of Qiaopi Trade and Transnational Networks” and “The Qiaopi Trade as a Distinctive Form of Chinese Capitalism.” Their work represents the first book-length study in English of the origins, structure, and operations of the *qiao pi* trade.

1.3 CULTURAL AND SOCIAL DIMENSIONS

1.3.1 Traditional Values and Cultural Analysis

A significant strand of research examines how *qiao pi* embodied traditional Chinese values, particularly concepts of trust and familial responsibility that sustained remittance networks without formal legal protections. Niu (2013) demonstrates how traditional Confucian moral principles of “benevolence, righteousness, propriety, wisdom, and trustworthiness”⁶ permeate these archives, extending their significance beyond mere economic transactions. Li et al. (2023) further this analysis by examining how “trust culture”⁷ in Guangdong *qiao pi* functioned across personal, industry, and national levels. These studies consistently highlight how Confucian values of filial piety motivated the maintenance of transnational connections (Deng, 2009).

1.3.2 Gender Imbalances and Male-Centric Perspectives

Research on *qiao pi* largely reflects historical gender imbalances in overseas Chinese communities. Tian and Xiao (2015) examines letters between male family members, while Zhou (2020) quantifies this gender disparity, documenting that Singapore’s 1931 Hainanese community had a gender ratio of 1000:151 (male:female). This predominant focus on male perspectives has marginalised women’s voices and experiences in both the historical record and subsequent scholarly analysis.

1.4 THE CRITICAL GAP: MARGINALISED HAINANESE WOMEN’S VOICES

Given the extensive coverage discussed above, this research contributes to addressing gaps in the landscape by:

Deconstructing monolithic narratives of Chinese identity by including diverse voices, particularly those of Hainanese women

Singapore's position as a multicultural society with significant Chinese diaspora populations offers a critical alternative to the PRC's state-centered interpretations. As Frost (2003) argues, Singapore's approach to Chinese heritage necessarily differs from mainland narratives, creating space for what Ang (2001) describes as the "impossible position" of diaspora communities—caught between essentialist notions of Chinese identity and their own complex, hybrid experiences. This research leverages Singapore's unique cultural positioning to develop counter-narratives that deconstruct monolithic conceptions of "Chineseness" while creating new nexuses of connection.

1.5 MULTIPLE LAYERS OF MARGINALISATION

The National Museum of Singapore operates within a multicultural national narrative that positions Chinese heritage as one component of a diverse society rather than as an extension of mainland Chinese nationhood. Such institutional positioning creates space for what Yeoh and Kong (2012) describe as "multivocal heritage interpretations" that recognise diverse perspectives within and across ethnic categories.

Within this context, Hainanese women's correspondence represents voices subject to multiple layers of marginalisation. The Hainanese themselves were marginalised within broader Chinese society long before migration. Kiungchow (modern-day Haikou) was historically "an outpost where for over a thousand years Chinese officials were banished for offending their emperor" (Nield, 2015, p. 141). This profound geographical marginalisation shaped the island's cultural and economic development, positioning it as peripheral to mainstream Chinese society.

In Singapore, the Hainanese faced additional layers of marginalisation. Arriving later than other dialect groups, they constituted only the fifth-largest Chinese dialect group (Conceicao, 2023). Their linguistic differences made communication with other Chinese communities difficult, as their dialect was largely unintelligible to Hokkien, Teochew, and Cantonese speakers. Economically marginalised, they were forced into service sectors like cooking and domestic work as more lucrative trades were already dominated by earlier Chinese migrants.

Hainanese women thus experienced at least three intersecting layers of marginalisation: as residents of a peripheral island historically used for political exile; as late-arriving migrants to Singapore with linguistic barriers; and as women within patriarchal structures that viewed female migration with suspicion. Their correspondence represents what Bhabha (1994) would describe as "border lives" at the intersection of multiple forms of marginality—experiences that profoundly challenge simplistic nationalist narratives centered on patriotic loyalty to the motherland.

1.6 THE CHALLENGE OF MAKING LETTERS ACCESSIBLE

Beyond the political dimensions of interpretation, Chinese diaspora correspondence presents significant practical challenges for contemporary museum display. As Serrell (2015) discusses, lengthy exhibit labels can lead to reduced visitor engagement in museum settings. This engagement challenge is particularly acute for materials written in classical Chinese or regional dialects, which remain inaccessible to many visitors including younger Singaporeans.

Traditional approaches to presenting historical correspondence—through translated displays, video recreations, or touchscreen interactives—frequently fail to create meaningful engagement with these materials. As Smith (2006) argues, heritage interpretations often impose fixed narratives that privilege curatorial authority over visitor meaning-making. Digital interfaces, while providing information access, often create what Parry (2010) describes as "informational rather than affective engagement" (p. 123)—privileging factual knowledge over emotional connection.

This recognition has led to our exploration of biometric approaches to visitor engagement—specifically, heart rate synchronisation as a means of creating embodied connections with historical materials. By translating the emotional content of letters into sound experiences that respond to visitors' heart rates, we address both the political challenge of challenging

2. New Museology and Embodied Experience Applied

Our approach integrates new museology and embodied experience to create a coherent framework for understanding and engaging with marginalised diaspora correspondence. These interconnected perspectives inform both our analysis of letter content and our development of biometric engagement methods.

As articulated by Hooper-Greenhill (2000), new museology questions authoritative curatorial voices and seeks more democratic, visitor-centred, and multivocal presentations of cultural artefacts. This theoretical framework positions museums not simply as repositories of objects but as sites of experience, meaning-making, and social engagement. Simon’s (2010) concept of the “participatory museum” also provides a particularly relevant framework for this research.

Complementary to this is Gurian’s (2006) concept of “essential museums,” which emphasises that objects serve primarily as conduits for human connection and storytelling rather than as ends in themselves. This perspective is particularly valuable for text-heavy artefacts like letters, which derive their significance not from their material properties but from the human experiences and relationships they embody.

The biometric application is also grounded in emerging scholarship on embodied knowledge and affective history. Crouch (2003) argues that bodily engagement transforms abstract knowledge into lived experience, creating deeper and more meaningful connections to cultural content. Similarly, Witcomb (2013) demonstrates how affective engagement in museum spaces can create stronger connections to historical materials than purely cognitive approaches. By synchronising visitors’ heart rates with soundscapes derived from letter content, the installation creates emotional and bodily connections that collapse temporal distance and foreground shared human experiences across historical contexts, aligning with Ahmed’s (2014) exploration of how emotions can bridge temporal and cultural divides. Tröndle and Tschacher’s (2012) research on “embodied resonance” between visitors and cultural artefacts supports our approach to creating affective connections through biometric synchronisation.

This integrated framework supports a multi-sensorial approach to heritage engagement where visitors “feel” their way into historical experiences that might otherwise remain inaccessible. By synchronising traditional percussion patterns to visitors’ heart rates, we create what Witcomb (2015) describes as a “pedagogy of feeling”—learning through emotional and bodily engagement rather than purely intellectual analysis. This approach addresses what she identifies as the challenge of creating “affective histories” that engage emotional and bodily responses alongside intellectual understanding.

3. Methodology: From Content to Experience - Letters, Heartbeats, and Sound

Having reviewed the corpus of relevant existing studies and areas in which this paper aims to contribute, the following section will detail how we arrive at the chosen letters, discuss further the value of heart rate synchronisation as well as the final prototype developed.

3.1 LETTER SELECTION

The selection of *qiao pi* for analysis followed a multi-stage filtering process. Beginning with 2,265 items from the National Museum of Singapore’s collection containing the keyword “letter,” we excluded non-paper materials to reach 887 items. Further manual review identified 385 Chinese letters, from which we focused particularly on correspondence involving Hainanese women.

Our focus on Hainanese women’s letters was both incidental and deliberate. Incidental because these were among the few letters in the collection that featured a female sender or recipient, and deliberate in addressing significant gaps in existing research which has predominantly examined male-authored correspondence. It’s worth noting that some letters may have been written by professional letter writers rather than the stated senders themselves, as literacy rates were low, particularly among women. However, even professionally written letters would typically capture the sender’s intended messages and concerns, filtered though they might be through the scribe’s writing conventions.

Our analysis of Hainanese women’s letters reveals themes and concerns that are more quotidian than nationalistic. Two specific letters exemplify these counter-narratives:

Letter 1 · He Aifang to He Qinge

Letter from He Aifang (何爱芳) to He Qinge (何庆娥) in Haikou, Hainan, dated March 2, 1960. National Museum of Singapore, Accession No. 2000-06963-004, “Remittance letters delivered by Shun Chen Rong Remittance House.”

順成隆匯兌信局

32 330
40
370

姑話

公元一九五六年

三月

二日

親愛的姑母大人表兄姊妹們：
今天接到姑母大人你們的回信及港幣叁拾元，真使女非常高興。女從小沒有和姑母的見面，現今拜着姑母的位都如見着姑母的面一樣。情況女也清楚了，女在家不時的想念着你們在外，女希望大人們在外多多保重，兄姊妹們身體為要，耐若繼續教兄姊妹們到學校讀書。工作太多，不得到上學，現在非常困難。姑母大人，女和祖母分開，真使女難過不少。祖母不在，女連飯不吃，天天心中經常有難過的存在。時常想念着祖母，姑母，這是不為法的分開了。姑母大人，女很想念你們，見面和坐談，這不能提到嘴，女的心不時不刻的想念着你們，現在在家冬冬，常受冤，料必在來情況姑母也知道了，冬方重冬人，有冬人的困難，不同，姑母你在外時常都有親愛，南想通信，馬車都不知，道，女最希望姑母今後要多多和女通信吧，這是在姑母大大的希望。姑母在十二月廿四日是卅付回的東西，女已收衣服二件。

女何愛芳字

祝你們身體健康
下次再敘

Letter 1. From He Aifang to He Qinge (March 2, 1960). Source: National Museum of Singapore, Accession No. 2000-06963-004.

The letter acknowledges receipt of Hong Kong dollars and discusses the education of siblings—content that centres family relationships and educational planning rather than national allegiance.

Letter 2 · A mother in Hainan to Fu Zhifeng

Letter from a mother in Hainan to her son Fu Zhifeng (符致逢), dated March 10, 1954. National Museum of Singapore, Accession No. 2000-06965-002, "Letter to Fu Zhi Fong from mother in Hainan."

吾兒致達：

你前次的來信已經收到了 隨信
又收到港幣伍拾元 諸日念

近來我的病是越來越重了 屢次請醫都
不見效 同時我老花眼已有三個月 欲
要起牀都不能了 家裡又沒有人來替我理家 希望
你最近返家來 同時也帶你的小姑和侄兒一齊歸
返 我很想見一見你們 你要回家來買些補藥或潤
子我這軟弱的身體 並祝

王康

九四.三

Letter 2. From a mother in Hainan to Fu Zhifeng (March 10, 1954). Source: National Museum of Singapore, Accession No. 2000-06965-002.

The letter mentions receipt of Hong Kong dollars, discusses the mother's health concerns, and requests a visit with tonics. The content centres intimate family relationships, bodily concerns, and practical matters rather than national or political themes.

These letters reveal what Scott (1990) describes as “hidden transcripts”—perspectives and experiences that exist outside officially sanctioned narratives. These materials document everyday concerns, family relationships, and personal struggles that complicate nationalist framings emphasising patriotic loyalty. By centring these marginalised voices, we contribute to what Chakrabarty (2000) describes as “provincializing” dominant historical frameworks.

The ordinary lives documented in Hainanese women's letters hold profound significance for world history. As Hsu (2000) argues, diaspora correspondence provides “history from below” that reveals how global forces—colonialism, capitalism, and nation-building—were experienced, negotiated, and sometimes resisted by ordinary people. The use of Hong Kong dollars reflects how these women navigated complex currency regimes and financial networks established by colonial powers. Their concerns about health, education, and family well-being demonstrate how care economies functioned across transnational spaces, maintaining social cohesion despite geographic separation.

3.2 THE UNIVERSALITY OF HEARTBEATS

The heart rate provides a particularly appropriate biometric signal for connecting visitors to historical materials for several reasons:

Truly Universal: Everyone has a heartbeat, creating a genuinely universal entry point to cultural materials that transcends linguistic, cultural, and educational differences.

Embodied Significance: The heartbeat carries powerful metaphorical associations with life, emotion, and human connection across most cultural traditions, making it an intuitive connector to historical materials about human relationships. Indeed, the heart is often metaphorically associated with emotions across cultures (Kövecses, 2000). The phrase “breathing life” into history becomes literal through this physiological connection.

Below Conscious Control: Heart rate operates both below conscious control and within awareness, representing a form of what Nacke et al. (2011) term “implicit interaction” (p. 103)—physiological engagement that occurs without deliberate user actions. This characteristic makes heart rate potentially valuable for museum contexts where visitors may feel self-conscious about explicit interactive behaviors (Hornecker & Stifter, 2006, p. 138).

Biofeedback Loop: This setup, where heart rate influences the soundscape and the soundscape may in turn affect the visitor’s physiological state, exemplifies a biofeedback loop, a concept well-established in physiological computing.

By using heart rate as the physiological bridge between visitor and historical material, we allow visitors to literally “feel” their way into someone else’s story, creating a multi-sensorial pathway to understanding that doesn’t require the ability to read classical Chinese.

3.3 INTERACTIVE PROTOTYPE: HEART-SYNCHRONISED PERCUSSION

Our interactive prototype translates the emotional content of Hainanese women’s letters into sound experiences synchronised with visitors’ heart rates. The system architecture comprises primary components as detailed below:

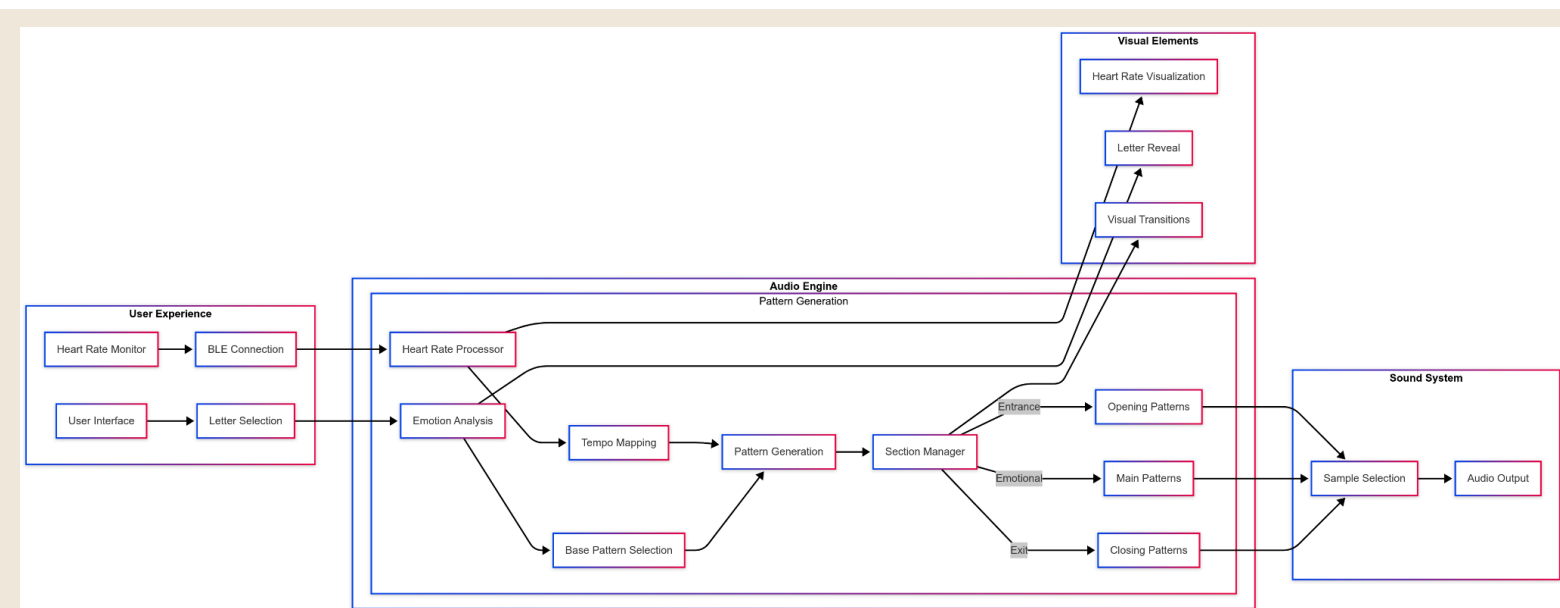


Figure 1. System diagram. Created by the author.

Heart Rate Integration: The system takes real-time heart rate data from a Bluetooth Low Energy (BLE) device, using a mapping function that converts physiological heart rates (60-120 BPM) to musical tempos (65-95 BPM). This creates a

direct connection between the visitor’s bodily state and the musical experience.

Letter Emotional Analysis: Each letter has predefined emotional metrics capturing its content, including emotional intensity, urgency, and dominant emotions. These metrics are based on close textual analysis of the letters. The emotional analysis component translates these textual emotional dimensions into parameters for sound generation, facilitating a cross-modal mapping from text to sound, a process central to the field of affective computing (Picard, 1997).

Musical Pattern Generation: The system generates percussion patterns structured in three sections (entrance, emotional, and exit), creating a complete narrative arc for each letter. The patterns use traditional opera percussion instruments—Bangu (板鼓) as the main rhythmic instrument, Daluo (大锣) for accent points, Xiaoluo (小锣) for ornamental flourishes, and Naobo (饶钹) for punctuation . For the purpose of quick prototyping, the percussions were taken from this dataset of Beijing opera as it was readily available (Tian, Srinivasamurthy, Sandler, & Serra, 2014). This approach creates what Kirshenblatt-Gimblett (1998) describes as “cultural resonance”—connections between historical materials and their living cultural contexts. The interactive experience follows a structured flow with three distinct phases:

Entrance Section: The experience begins with the gradual fade-in of visuals and simple rhythmic patterns as the visitor’s heart rate visualisation begins. This phase serves as a “scaffolded entry” that allows visitors to understand how their heart rate influences the experience before full engagement.

Emotional Section: The core experience features the full letter reveal, complex pattern variations, and peak emotional expression. During this phase, the visitor’s heart rate directly influences the tempo and intensity of the percussion patterns, creating an “affective resonance” between visitor and historical material.

Exit Section: The experience concludes with pattern simplification, visual fade-out, and gradual tempo reduction. This phase provides closure and reflection, embodying what Simon (2010) describes as the “me-to-we” design principle—moving from personal experience to broader social and historical connections.

This system creates a dynamic, responsive experience where the user’s heart rate influences both the musical and visual elements, while the emotional content of the letters provides the structural framework for the experience. The three-section structure (entrance, emotional, exit) ensures a complete narrative arc, while the real-time heart rate input keeps the experience personal and engaging.

4. Implications

This project demonstrates the practical application of key concepts from new museology. Its relevance to museum practice, in proposing counter-narratives and making visible marginalised voices will be discussed below.

4.1 MUSEUM PRACTICE TRANSFORMATION

The findings from this research have significant implications for museum practice, particularly for the display and interpretation of text-heavy historical artefacts. Traditional approaches to exhibiting letters—displaying them under glass with accompanying explanatory text—can create significant barriers to engagement, particularly for items in languages unfamiliar to most visitors (Bitgood, 2013). The biometric approach demonstrates a viable alternative that can significantly increase both engagement duration and emotional connection with such materials.

The biometric approach also offers practical solutions to engaging visitors across Singapore’s linguistically diverse population. By creating non-linguistic points of access to these materials, the installation enables meaningful engagement regardless of visitors’ fluency in Chinese dialects or Chinese writing, making these important historical materials accessible to all Singaporeans regardless of linguistic background.

For heritage institutions, particularly those in contexts like Singapore with complex relationships to larger nation-states like China, this research demonstrates practical approaches to developing counter-narratives that challenge dominant nationalist framings. By highlighting everyday concerns, women’s voices, and local contexts in the presentation of diaspora materials, museums can create more nuanced understandings of transnational experiences that resist subsumption under singular national narratives.

This approach has particular relevance in contemporary contexts where heritage increasingly functions as a domain of soft power and cultural diplomacy. As Winter (2015) notes in his analysis of heritage diplomacy in Asia, cultural institutions often navigate complex geopolitical dynamics in their presentation of shared heritage. Singapore’s presentation of Chinese diaspora materials in ways that acknowledge connections to China while emphasising distinctive local developments represents an important model for balancing these considerations.

4.3 AMPLIFYING ACCESS TO MARGINALISED VOICES

Perhaps most significantly, this research offers practical mechanisms for amplifying historically marginalised voices. By making women’s letters—often overlooked in traditional scholarship—accessible and emotionally resonant for contemporary audiences, the project demonstrates how technological innovation can serve broader goals of inclusivity and diverse representation in cultural heritage. For the National Museum of Singapore specifically, this approach aligns with institutional commitments to representing the nation’s multicultural heritage and complex historical relationships.

5. Conclusion and Future Research

In summary, “If Letters Home Could Sing” demonstrates how embodied heritage engagement can challenge nationalist narratives while making historically significant materials accessible to diverse audiences. For Singapore, this project represents an opportunity to deconstruct monolithic narratives of Chinese identity by including diverse voices, creating an alternative nexus of story that binds people together through shared human experience rather than national allegiance. By centring Hainanese women’s voices and developing innovative approaches to their presentation, Singapore’s heritage institutions can challenge the mono-narrative of patriotic loyalty to the motherland while affirming the global significance of ordinary lives that traversed national boundaries.

The methodology developed through this research demonstrates how embodied, physiological engagement can create meaningful connections with historically and linguistically complex materials. By literally allowing visitors to “breathe life” into historical letters through their heartbeats, we create possibilities for understanding the past not as a distant, fixed narrative but as a living presence that continues to resonate through our bodies and communities.

Future directions for this research include expanding the methodology to other marginalised correspondence in museum collections, developing more sophisticated emotional mapping techniques, and conducting longitudinal studies of visitor engagement and learning outcomes. The prototype can also be developed further with more informed musical involvement and clan institutions.

As museums globally seek ways to remain relevant in an increasingly digital world, “If Letters Home Could Sing” offers a model that transcends the binary of technological innovation versus human experience. Indeed, this research suggests a way forward where museums become spaces not just for preserving the past, but for creating living connections between cultural heritage and contemporary experience – one heartbeat at a time.

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Disclaimer. The opinions, findings, and recommendations expressed in this publication are those of the Research Fellow and do not necessarily reflect the views of the National Heritage Board.

On a personal note, this research is deeply inspired by and dedicated to the incredible Hainanese women in my life—my late mother and grandmother—whose strength, resilience, and wisdom continue to influence me. It feels particularly meaningful that the letters I found most compelling were written by Hainanese women; I did not set out specifically to find these voices, but perhaps they found their way to me. By amplifying these historically marginalised voices, I hope to honour my family heritage while revealing how women’s everyday concerns formed the essential yet often unacknowledged foundation upon which strong, transnational communities were built and sustained.

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Original text: “爱国主义视域下侨批档案的高校育人价值与实现路径” ↩

Original text: “华侨由对家庭、宗族、家乡的热爱，升华到对祖国的热爱” ↩

Original text: “本文尝试以闽南侨批为例，探讨利用侨批弘扬爱国顾家、守信重义、敬老爱幼等中华传统美德，进行爱国主义教育，推动侨乡经济、社会、文化健康和谐发展的可行路径” ↩

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